

How to use xclip on Linux

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Korbin Brown

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The **xclip** tool can be used to interact with the system clipboard from the [command line](#). This can come in handy in instances where you want to send information directly to the user's clipboard, without requiring that they highlight and copy the text themselves. It also works in the other direction, so the **xclip** command can check the contents of the clipboard.

When working with [bash scripting](#) to automate tasks, **xclip** is a life saver in certain scripts. In this tutorial, you will see how to install **xclip** on all [major linux distros](#), and then learn how to use the **xclip** command through practical examples. Let's see what it can do.

In this tutorial you will learn:

- How to install **xclip** on all major Linux distros
- How to use the **xclip** command in Linux

How to use xclip on Linux

Category	Requirements, Conventions or Software Version Used
System	Any Linux distro
Software	xclip

Category	Requirements, Conventions or Software Version Used
Other	Privileged access to your Linux system as root or via the sudo command.
Conventions	# – requires given linux commands to be executed with root privileges either directly as a root user or by use of sudo command \$ – requires given linux commands to be executed as a regular non-privileged user

Software Requirements and Linux Command Line Conventions

How to install xclip

Despite xclip being the useful tool that it is, it is often not included by default on various [Linux systems](#). You can use the appropriate command below to install xclip with your system's [package manager](#).

To install xclip on [Ubuntu](#), [Debian](#), and [Linux Mint](#):

```
$ sudo apt update
$ sudo apt install xclip
```

To install xclip on [Fedora](#), [CentOS](#), [AlmaLinux](#), and [Red Hat](#):

```
$ sudo dnf install xclip
```

To install xclip on [Arch Linux](#) and [Manjaro](#):

```
$ sudo pacman -S xclip
```

DID YOU KNOW?

The “x” in “xclip” refers to the X window manager. xclip specifically interacts with the clipboard that belongs to X (X11 / Xorg), so the behavior might vary a bit depending on which window manager you are using. For example, Wayland uses a separate clipboard, but you can still access the X clipboard (and therefore xclip) via the middle mouse button in terminal or other X program.

How to use xclip command on Linux

Now that the tool has been installed, let's see how it can be useful to us by looking at some practical command examples below.

1. You can pipe output to `xclip` if you want it to end up on the user's clipboard instead of in their terminal. For example, we can `cat` a file and send the output directly to the clipboard:

```
$ cat myfile.txt | xclip
```

If using the X window system, the contents of `myfile.txt` will not be on your clipboard. Otherwise, it is still accessible using the middle mouse button.

2. `xclip` can also take the contents of your clipboard. For example, to output the clipboard, use the `-o` option.

```
$ xclip -o
```

3. Or to send the clipboard's content directly to a file, use Bash shell redirection `>` operator:

```
$ xclip -o > myfile.txt
```

4. To place a text string into `xclip` and your clipboard, you can use `echo` and pipe the string to `xclip`.

```
$ echo "welcome to linuxconfig.org" | xclip
```

5. To interact with the system clipboard, rather than the X window clipboard, you can use the `-selection` option. For example, we can supply the `clipboard` argument to instruct `xclip` to copy the text to the same clipboard accessible through the right click context menu.

```
$ cat myfile.txt | xclip -selection clipboard
```

If you want to use `xclip` to access the other clipboard with `-o`, make sure you specify the correct `-selection` once more:

```
$ xclip -o -selection clipboard
```

6. `xclip` can simplify tasks that would ordinarily take a few steps to complete. For example, we can `ssh` to a remote host and copy the contents of a file to our clipboard, with it ready to paste into any program or terminal that we want.

```
$ ssh user@host "cat /myfile.txt" | xclip -selection clipboard
```

Closing Thoughts

In this tutorial, we saw how to install and use the `xclip` command on a Linux system. `Xclip` is the perfect tool for accessing the contents of the clipboard from the command line, or for placing text on the clipboard. It has access to both the X system clipboard and the user's system clipboard, depending on your use case.